DO YOU KNOW?

In 1950s, **Maurice Wilkins and Rosalind Franklin** *of Kings College, London studied the X-ray crystallography and revealed experimental data on the structure of DNA*

8.7.3 Features of DNA

- If one strand runs in the 5′-3′ direction, the other runs in 3′-5′ direction and thus are antiparallel (they run in opposite direction). The 5′ end has the phosphate group and 3'end has the OH group.
- The angle at which the two sugars protrude from the base pairs is about 120°, for the narrow angle and 240° for the wide angle. The narrow angle between the sugars generates a **minor groove** and the large angle on the other edge generates **major groove.**
- Each base is 0.34 nm apart and a complete turn of the helix comprises 3.4 nm or 10 base pairs per turn in the predominant B form of DNA.
- DNA helical structure has a diameter of 20 A° and a pitch of about 34 A°. X-ray crystal study of DNA takes a stack of about 10 bp to go completely around the helix (360°).
- Thermodynamic stability of the helix and specificity of base pairing includes (i) the hydrogen bonds between the complementary bases of the double helix (ii) stacking interaction between bases tend to stack about each other perpendicular to the direction of helical axis. Electron cloud interactions (∏ – ∏) between the bases in the helical stacks contribute to the stability of the double helix.
- The phosphodiester linkages gives an inherent polarity to the DNA helix. They form strong covalent bonds, gives the strength and stability to the polynucleotide chain (Figure 8.32).

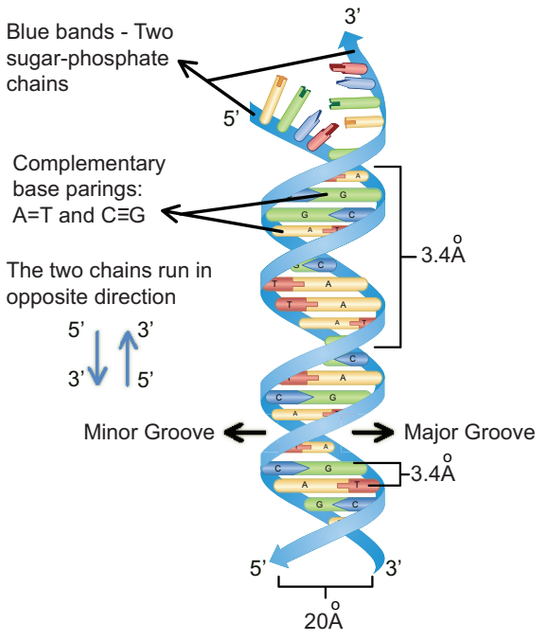


Figure 8.26: Structure of DNA

- Plectonemic coiling - the two strands of the DNA are wrapped around each other in a helix, making it impossible to simply move them apart without breaking the entire structure. Whereas in paranemic coiling the two strands simply lie alongside one another, making them easier to pull apart.
- Based on the helix and the distance between each turns, the DNA is of three forms – **A DNA, B DNA and Z DNA** (Figure 8.27).

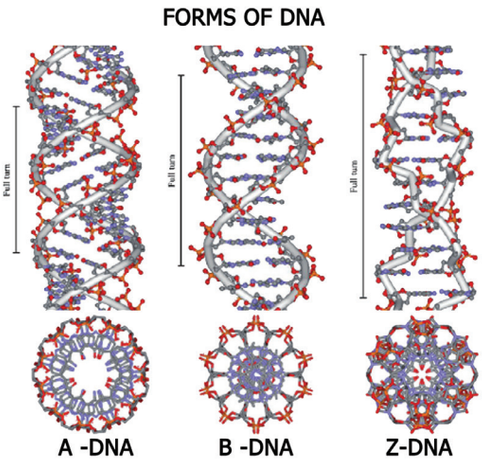


Figure 8.27: Forms of DNA

8.7.4 Ribonucleic Acid (RNA)

Ribonucleic acid (**RNA**) is a polymeric molecule essential in various biological roles in

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